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Introduction

Due to the rise of new media, people who do not even know each other's names can find ways to talk, advise each other, and gain insight thanks to the rise of public online forums. These forums often focus on a specific topic; people with knowledge on this particular topic tend to gravitate towards these forums and help anyone with any questions relating to the issue at hand. These public forums are driven by the concept of affective publics, which are defined as emotional drivers of conversation among people.

The public conversation that I have selected is the r/UMass Subreddit, which belongs to the Reddit online forum. Reddit is home to multiple forums - Subreddits - on various kinds of topics from cheese ([r/Cheese](#)) to Taylor Swift ([r/TaylorSwift](#)) and, of course, the University of Massachusetts Amherst ([r/UMass](#)). The r/UMass Subreddit is significant in the context of new media and affective publics, because it allows for college students to discuss issues that matter to them - whether these issues are relevant to a specific time or not.

The threads that I will focus on are "[housing help desperately needed](#)" (BlueFireGriffin), which was relevant due to housing appointments being held during the transition between March and April, and "[Having almost no friends](#)" (FlanTraditional7979), which is a common concern among college students. The threads demonstrate the significance of new media by allowing people with different perspectives and insights to help each other in certain situations, even if they do not know each other personally.

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“housing help desperately needed”

UMass Amherst held housing appointments for the majority of its students between March 26 and April 4, 2025 (“Fall Online Room Selection”). There were instances where people had difficulty during the process and had to ask various sources for help. One such source was Reddit, as demonstrated by BlueFireGriffin in their post “housing help desperately needed.” The user detailed how they had failed to confirm their housing selection and was debating whether to search for housing away from campus or make a late appointment. While “housing help desperately needed” seems like a simple cry for help at the outset - especially given that there were only five replies to the thread that were not automated - it was a conversation between college students in similar circumstances. Reddit’s ability to allow people to discuss issues that affect them establish its position as a place for affective public discourse. Further, the colloquial language, casual tone used by stakeholders, and allowance for continued conversation by the app, enhances Reddit’s ability to get people to engage with topics that affect them.

Zizi Papacharissi writes about the importance of technology and how it influences affective publics, topics that bring about public discourse. When it comes to public discussions including those afforded by Reddit, “impact is symbolic, agency is claimed discursively and is of a semantic nature, and power accessed is liminal” (Jenkins). Where Reddit is concerned, agency on what to say is indeed distributed based on what the topic at hand is, which makes its nature as a tool for affective discourse all the more powerful. The topic of housing on campus is important: not everyone is guaranteed a place to stay while they study. What is more, housing in the state of Massachusetts is not cheap, and on-campus housing is sometimes the easiest way for students to

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find accommodation. The original poster was in a difficult position when they posted this, and other users were quick to offer their insights. One asked if the original poster had a screenshot confirming their initial room selection; another suggested where they could look for off-campus housing, and a third simply empathized with the original poster. All of the students participating in “housing help desperately needed” can understand BlueFireGriffin’s situation, as they too are affected by it to some extent: they offer potential solutions to the problem, and one shares in their stress: “that sounds awful:(hope it all figures out for you nobody deserves the amount of stress this housing process has caused people” (EngineNo2947). Reddit is serving as a vehicle for people to discuss how they are impacted by the increasing scarcity of housing, giving them the agency to speak on an issue that affects them.

Another significant element of this thread is the colloquial tone used by the people who reply to the original poster. EngineNo2947’s quote - “that sounds awful:(hope it all figures out for you nobody deserves the amount of stress this housing process has caused people” - exemplifies the friendly, concerned nature of the Redditors who have been using this thread. The message uses an emoticon and little to no punctuation, yet it gets straight to the point and expresses sympathy and well-wishes for BlueFireGriffin as they continue to mull over their situation. By allowing people to reply to others’ comments, Reddit allows people to show each other that they are on the same page and at the same level when it comes to problems that they have in common. The allowance of replies also cements Reddit’s power as a new media-based conversation tool. A study conducted by Jinhyeon Kim, Jinyoung Han and Daejin Choi explores the continuous nature of Reddit conversations, concluding that “the proposed model can provide

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the potential insights to advertisers, opinion leaders, or people who want to understand and predict the evolutionary process of threaded conversations” (Kim et al). The reason these conversations are continuous is because Reddit is an open space for original posts and replies of any kind: if someone finds a way they can help a fellow Redditor, either with advice or moral support, then the field is all theirs to post a reply and do so.

In conclusion, “housing help desperately needed” is a thread that encapsulates Reddit’s sheer power as a conversational tool amidst the rise of new media. Its tendency towards affective discourse puts people on an equal footing when they discuss issues that affect them, and its allowance for casual, continuous conversations allows people to help each other should they have any problems.

“Having almost no friends”

While “housing help desperately needed” focuses on an issue that was specific to the UMass campus at a specific period in time, “Having almost no friends,” posted by Redditor FlanTraditional7979, is centered around an issue that can affect college students on any campus at any time. The original poster admits that it is difficult for them to form genuine friendships with other people on campus, and despite their efforts, they find that they cannot do so. “Having almost no friends” focuses on how Reddit, as a new media tool, can help people deal with problems - in this case, mental health and loneliness - by way of affective publics and online conversations. Further, Reddit’s allowance for people to use visual elements to convey their emotions - in this case, emojis - is a further example of how affective publics can resonate with this particular audience of college students.

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In the article “Showing They Care (Or Don’t): Affective Publics and Ambivalent Climate Activism on TikTok,” Samantha Hautea, Perry Parks, Bruno Takahashi and Jing Zeng talk about how TikTok has served as an effective vehicle for climate change activism; due to their conversational nature as new media tools, Reddit, r/Umass, and the “Having almost no friends” thread are similar to TikTok. The article on climate change activism focuses on how awareness of environmental problems is spread by way of “discursive, intertextual, and memetic linkages that propagate affective publics,” which bring about an emotional resonance that draws people to the issue at hand (Hautea et al). “Having almost no friends,” in turn, has an emotional resonance, because people genuinely hear what FlanTraditional 7979 says: they empathize with the original poster, share their experiences, and offer potential solutions. One user proposes that the original poster talk to people in their classes, given that people with the same major have common ground (ringularity1). Another talks about having ADHD and how they sometimes feel that they alienate people due to their quirks (HeftyHistorian9067) while yet another proposes, “...what if there was some planned hangout for people here who are struggling with socializing, think that'd be pretty neat” (Ok-Fan-5226). Affective publics are very much at play here: the conversation is powered by what people are affected by, and their resulting emotions. As a platform, Reddit allows these people to talk about their emotions freely; even though they do not know each other, they speak about what is on their minds and develop meaningful, if temporary, relationships that can give them some respite and solutions.

There is another element that Reddit allows people to communicate with - emojis. Emojis are visual figures used in text messages that “express a range of objects and ideas” (Kendall).

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When used among the college students who frequent the thread, they capture the way they feel, which enhances the affective publics that drive the conversation and, in turn, benefit the original poster by providing them with a resonant message. User hoanhding ends their message by saying: “Imagine being surrounded by finance bros in all of your classes. 😊 I’m down to make new friends any day!! 🥰” (hoanhding). These are the only two emojis that the user includes in their message, but they make its sympathetic nature clear. First, the “😊” emoji, used after hoanhding’s statement about spending time with the same kind of people every day, arguably establishes that the user often finds themselves out of their depth in their classroom, given that the people around them have little in common with them. The second emoji, “🥰,” is used immediately after they express their wish to make new friends. These visuals convey emotion in a way that regular words cannot: they establish the relatively casual nature of the poster, and in turn, mark a friendly but empathetic conversation between two college students. They do not take away from how the poster feels: rather, they make it clear how much they want to meet new friends, and thus, connect with the original poster and drive the affective publics of the conversation. A little community, where people can support each other through their loneliness, is allowed to exist on Reddit, which uses new media as a tool for conversation.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the Reddit threads “housing help desperately needed” and “Having almost no friends,” both part of the r/UMass subreddit, establish the community-building power of Reddit as a tool of both new media and affective publics, because they allow students to casually discuss relevant problems and build communities over the use of technology. While “housing

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help desperately needed” gives room for discussions on a student-centered problem at a specific time, “Having almost no friends” discusses a problem that many students face in general - loneliness - and allows people to find ways to work on their situations. Additionally, the use of emojis as visuals, especially in the second thread, allow students to maintain a casual rapport as they build up online communities on campus.

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